

Alternative Assessment – Research Proposal &
Discussion Topics

BMKT 502 MARKETING RESEARCH

SEMESTER 1 2014/2015

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Table of Contents

1. Introduction	3
1.1 Company Background Information	3
1.2 Rationale for the Research	3
2. Research Objectives	4
3. Methodology	4
3.1 Desk Research	5
3.1.2 Purpose	5
3.1.3 Procedure.....	6
3.2 Observation.....	6
3.3 Field Research.....	7
3.3.1 Workshops.....	8
A. Purpose.....	8
B. Procedure.....	8
3.3.2 In-depth Interviews.....	8
A. Purpose.....	8
B. Procedure.....	8
C. Pilot Study.....	9
3.3.3 Sampling Size.....	9
A. Workshops.....	9
B. In-depth Interviews.....	10
4. Reporting.....	11
5. Timing.....	11
6. Budget.....	12
7. Other Key Consideration (Limitation).....	13
8. Credentials & Quality Control.....	14
9. Reference.....	15
10. Appendices.....	16

Glossary & Abbreviations

CSR – Corporate Social Responsibility

EC – European Commission

ECOCERT - Ecocert is an inspection and certification body established in France in 1991 by agronomists aware of the need to develop environmentally friendly agriculture and of the importance of offering some form of recognition to those committed to this method of production. From its creation, Ecocert is specialized in the certification of organic agricultural products.

ISO 20252 - ISO 20252 is an international standard entitled "Market, opinion and social research, Vocabulary and service requirements".

MRS – Market Research Society

1. Introduction

1.1 Company Background information

L'Occitane en Provence, usually referred to as L'Occitane is an intentional retailer of natural beauty products with a vast history and reputation of over 30 years. The company was founded in 1976 by Olivier Baussan who started to sell Rosemary oil on the local markets with the purpose of preserving the tradition of his native Provence. Based in Manosque, France – the base where the products are manufactured and developed, L'Occitane has a strong global image in terms of green trading, green marketing and eco-friendly procedures and goods. Most of the products and ingredients used are in line with the organic cosmetics specifications of Ecocert (L'OCCITANE en Provence, 2014).

1.2 Rationale for the Research

According to the Department for Environment for Food & Rural Affairs (Reducing and managing waste, 2013) England generates almost 177 million tons of waste every year causing serious environmental damage. Along the years, a series of laws (based on EC legal requirements) has been imposed on businesses to recycle a portion of their production - from packaging, batteries, electrical equipment to vehicles. These restrictions also triggered the development of CSR among mass market brands being used as a sword with two edges – obeying the governmental rules and increasing firms' reputation.

Nowadays, corporate social responsibility represents one of the most disputable topic among business practitioners and organisations' stakeholders. It is often acknowledged that CSR is a powerful instrument which increases corporate reputation but there some polemics that perceive it as expensive and inconsistent with the corporate goal of protecting stakeholders' privileges (Blowfield and Murray, 2011).

In the light of these underlying principles, as a research executive I have been commissioned by a Marketing Research Agency to produce a research proposal with the aim of examining L'Occitane stakeholders' attitudes in Greater London towards its reputation with regard to recycling. An ongoing stakeholders' consultation is adopted in relation to the company green mission with the purpose of gathering enough information for the study.

2. Research Objectives

- A. To determine the recycling issues that are important to the organisation's stakeholders (in Greater London)
 - 1) To identify L'Occitane stakeholders;
 - 2) To obtain an understanding of stakeholders' current level of awareness of recycling
 - 3) To evaluate what are the main recycling issues in the cosmetic industry that are significant for the stakeholders.

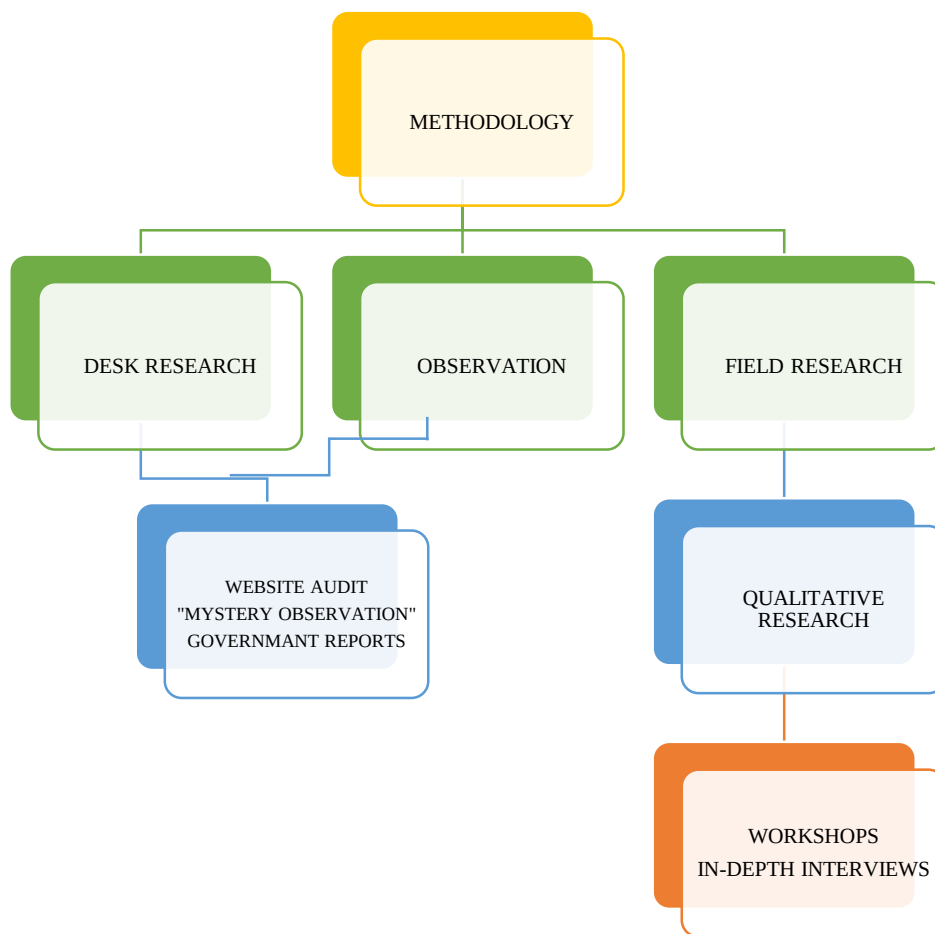
- B. To examine the different attitudes of different stakeholders (in Greater London) towards the organisation's position on the identified recycling issues.
 - 1) To investigate L'Occitane's involvement and actions taken with respect to the identified recycling issues.
 - 2) To assess if there is a consensus among stakeholders regarding L'Occitane's action towards the identified recycling issues.
 - 3) To explore the discrepancy between stakeholders' views by identifying the source of this inconsistency.

- C. To compare the organisation's performance against other competing organisations that demonstrate good practice.
 - 1) To identify the main competitors in the cosmetic industry in Greater London.
 - 2) To evaluate the points of difference and points of parity between L'Occitane ethical performance and its competition.

3. Methodology

The research design encompasses both primary and secondary research. At the first stage, the desk research will provide more background knowledge of the main recycling issues in the cosmetics industry and L'Occitane stakeholders and competitors. Furthermore, the primary research includes qualitative investigation using 3 workshops and 6 in-depth interviews.

Figure 1 – Methodology



3.1 Desk Research

3.1.1 Purpose

Due to the research objectives it is clearly seen that desk research and observation will help to develop a series of parameters for recruiting stakeholders and assessing their views towards recycling. Initially, extensive desk research will be completed to acknowledge L'Occitane both internal and external stakeholders in Greater London. Furthermore, the main recycling issues together with our client's position in regards to this aspect will be identified. A careful consideration will be addressed to the environmental actions taken by L'Occitane looking in particular into five main areas:

3.1.2 Procedure

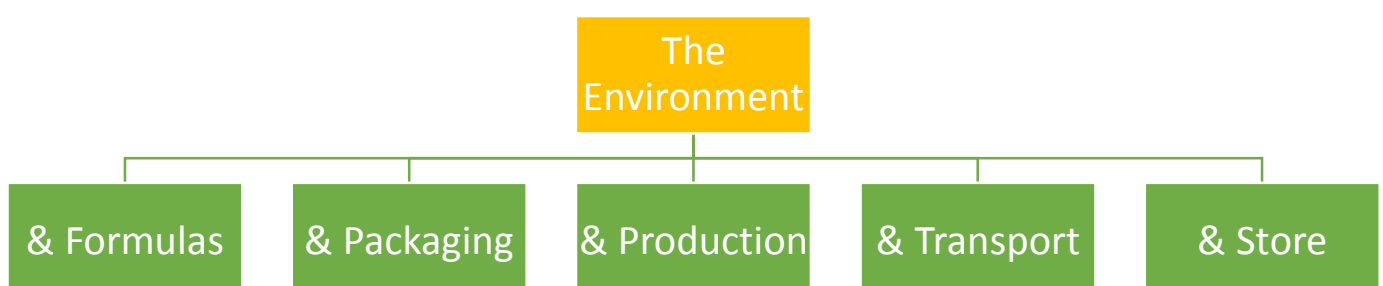
L'Occitane en Provence Website provides up-to-date testimonials regarding its Corporate Social Responsibility, implicitly its recycling activities. Firstly, the most recent governmental reports on waste and recycling statistic (issued by the Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs) will be analysed with the purpose of understanding the most significant recycling issues in the cosmetics industry. Furthermore, L'Occitane CSR Reports and press releases will support the research by matching the current environmental issues and client's actions to overcome them. Through L'Occitane Annual Reports the internal stakeholders such as suppliers and employees will be identified (Issuu, 2013). Additional web sources – social platforms, L'Occitane Customers Platform or various consumer/social communities will be monitored for recognizing the company's customers.

3.2 Observation

A Website Audit (See Appendix 4) will be completed to identify L'Occitane main stores in Greater London. In addition, the mystery shopping technique will be used for a more accurate perspective of who is using L'Occitane beauty products and for determining the proportion of customers – external stakeholders - who will be asked to take part in the workshops.

This study includes “mystery observation” which comprises the factual observation of points of sale or services focusing particularly on products packaging, recycling in-store and customers purchase behaviour – if they are influenced by product green features or not. This approach could be extended to an actual purchase – acting as a potential customer – or customers' enquiry to assess the sales employees' (another stakeholder group) approach towards informing customers about recycling. Although, additional actions are time consuming and as stakeholders' attitudes will be further assessed in the workshops and in-depth interviews, the extension will not take place.

Figure 2 – Recycling Areas



L'Occitane high street competitors will be also identified through observation and their green, ethical practices will be compared with L'Occitane by consulting the most recent National Audit Office and Government Watchdog Reports on recycling and mass market brands. At an early stage, a content analysis will be established with the purpose of systematically identifying the presence of certain recycling issues, the main ethical concepts in relation to these issues and L'Occitane stakeholders. Furthermore, conceptual and relational analyses will be further carried out to explore the most frequent recycling concerns in the industry and examine the relationship among them, stakeholders' attitudes and L'Occitane corporate reputation.

Using Observation as primary research for this study, it will help overcoming three main limitations – time, subjectivity and over-researching. Thus, the subjectivity of having participants recruited from a single place for the qualitative research will be avoided by visiting several L'Occitane shops across Greater London. Also, it is valuable for the future sampling identification together with the certainty of having enough people recruited for the workshops and interviews. Time and over-researching are saved through observation achieving an insight into who is using L'Occitane recycling products instead of approaching random customers.

This research was completed according to the MRS Code of Practice, respecting the individual privacy and assuring that data subjects will not be disadvantaged as a result of this work. Furthermore, adequate security arrangements were made between the staff members and the companies – L'Occitane and competitions by notifying them with 72 hours in advance about the study and the objectives of the study and ensuring that any personal data are secure and not accessible by unauthorised parties.

3.3 Field Research

Survey Methods

Survey methods will be used in form of qualitative research because the main purpose of the research is to gain an understanding of the expense of attitudes and opinions regarding recycling. According with the research objectives' nature this research does not have a quantitative stage – the aim of this research is to explore the diversity of stakeholders' attitudes towards recycling not to establish their intensity or frequency.

3.3.1 Workshops

A. Purpose

To explore L'Occitane's stakeholders' attitudes regarding the main recycling issues a survey will be made in form of three workshops – compared with discussion groups, a workshop recruits more people (around 18 or so, rather than about 8 for a discussion group). Workshops also run for a longer period of time (5 -5.5 hours, rather than 1.5– 2 hours) and therefore allow for greater exchange of views, discussion and participation. Judging on the research objectives, they are ideal for assessing and digesting the complex concept of recycling and also for a broad range of participants with many different experiences and knowledge of L'Occitane – as customers, employees and suppliers' representatives will be attending the workshops. The mediator will have the opportunity to divide and mix people up into smaller syndicate groups (comprising different types of people in each syndicate) to debate issues.

B. Procedure

Each workshop comprises 22 people will be held in the following locations: Oxford Street, Covent Garden and Kensington Street Cardiff to give a very accessible and convenient sweet of Greater London.

3.3.2 In-depth Interviews

A. Purpose

6 face-to-face in-depth interviews will be used to understand and deeply explore L'Occitane's stakeholders' attitudes, opinions and expectations of recycling issues and actions taken by the company providing qualitative responses and research. This stage represents an extension of the previous qualitative research – workshops – as the hypothesis generated within the workshops could be further used during the interviews for maximizing the data quality previously collected. This approach has been considered in order to minimize the limitations which may occur during the workshops. The participants are speaking in a specific context within a specific culture and it is very likely they will not express their own definitive individual view. Therefore, it may be difficult for the researcher to clearly underpin a single message – action which can be taken during the in-depth interviews.

B. Procedure

Face-to-face interviews have been chosen over telephone interviews as moderator can clarify any doubt and ensure that the questions are properly understood, helping us to achieve more accurate

and valid results. Also, non-verbal behaviours could be analysed giving the interviewee the possibility to comprehend what the respondents is really trying to communicate. This aspect would not be possible to detect in a telephone interview.

C. Pilot Study

Before the actual fieldwork, a pilot study is planned to be conducted in a group similar to the one who will be recruited for the interviews. As the workshops will take place before the in-depth interviews and the sampling is very similar for both methods, they afford the opportunity to investigate and evaluate the appropriateness of the interview questions guides. The experience in the field together will emphasize the areas of confusions, ambiguity or other issues relating to the study environment so later problems could be avoid. Any amendments discovered at this stage would be applied to the discussion topics guide before issuing a final version.

3.3.3 Sampling and Sample Size (both Qualitative Methods)

A **Stratified Quota** sampling method shall be used during both the workshops and in depth interviews. There will be will a separate quota at each of the 3 stakeholders categories – customers, suppliers’ representatives and employees - with a further stratification based on gender to ensure that a bias does not get formed by having all males or all females from one category. There could also be another quota relating to the buying/working history or the knowledge accuracy regarding recycling however this will delay the completion time of the research. This sampling method is used instead of random sample because it provides a more accurate image of who is suitable for this research.

However, in qualitative research the sample size cannot be as predetermined as in the quantitative studies, data being collected until the researcher reaches the saturation point. The concept of saturation point is highly subjective as the researcher decides upon it. This limitation can be overcome by running the workshops – in a collective when no information is emerging it is assumed that the saturation point has been reached.

A. Workshops

Every group will include candidates due to specific criteria such as:

Type of Stakeholders

10 customers who purchased L’Occitane products in the last 6 months

7 L’Occitane Employees – working within L’Occitane for more than 6 months

5 Suppliers’ Representatives

Gender

An even distribution between females and males will overcome subjectivity and provide a better interpretation of the findings:

Customers – 5 females & 5 males

Employees – 5 females & 2 males

Suppliers' Representatives – 2 females & 3 males

Table 1 – Sample Size (Workshops)

<i>Recruitment Parameters</i>	<i>Sample Size</i>					
	<u>10 customers</u>		<u>7 L'Occitane Employees</u>		<u>5 Suppliers' Representatives</u>	
<i>Type of Stakeholders</i>	who purchased L'Occitane products in the last 6 months		working within L'Occitane for more than 6 months			
<i>Gender</i>	<u>5 Females</u>	<u>5 Males</u>	<u>5 Females</u>	<u>2 Males</u>	<u>2 Females</u>	<u>3 Males</u>

*Note – The geographic aspect is not part of the stratification as it has been conveyed that only stakeholders' attitudes in Greater London will be assessed.

B. In-depth Interviews

Type of Stakeholders

2 customers who purchased L'Occitane products in the last 6 months

2 L'Occitane Employees – working within L'Occitane for more than 6 months

2 Suppliers' Representatives

Gender

Customers – 1 female & 1 male

Employees – 1 female & 2 male

Suppliers' Representatives – 1 female & 1 male

Table 2 – Sample Size (In-depth Interviews)

<i>Recruitment Parameters</i>	<i>Sample Size</i>					
<i>Type of Stakeholders</i>	<u>2 customers</u> who purchased L'Occitane products in the last 6 months		<u>2 L'Occitane Employees</u> working within L'Occitane for more than 6 months		<u>2 Suppliers' Representatives</u>	
<i>Gender</i>	<u>1 Female</u>	<u>1 Male</u>	<u>1 Female</u>	<u>1 Male</u>	<u>1 Female</u>	1 <u>Male</u>

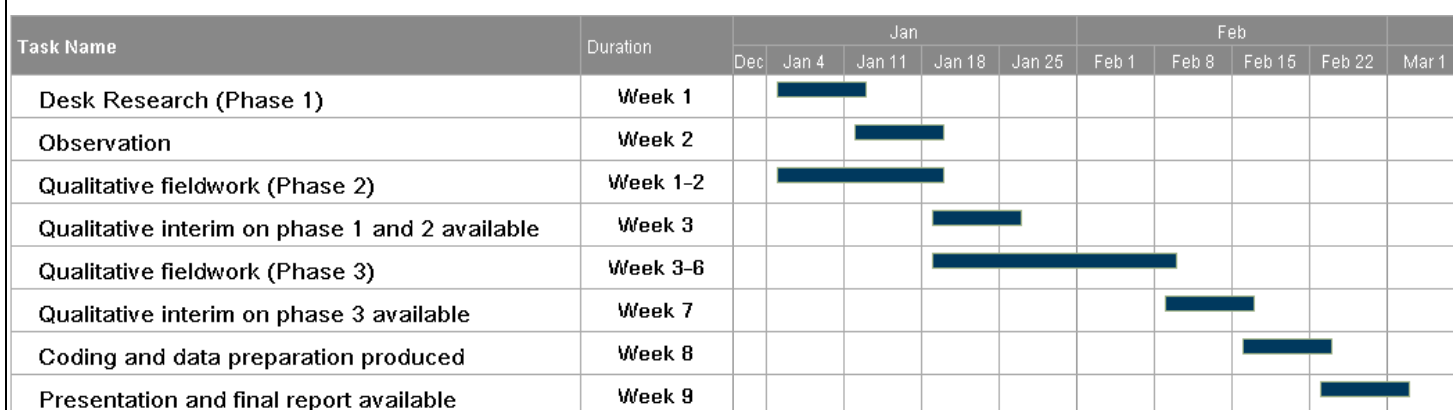
4. Reporting

Three copies of the report will be submitted at different stages during the research conducted. The first two papers will highlight the most important phases of research already available while the third one comprises the ultimate report with all the findings and data analysis to be delivered. Taking heed of the qualitative research formula encompassing workshops and in-depth interviews, the marketing agency will include the findings of the first half of the qualitative research - workshops - within the two prior copies. Following the completion of the second stage – in-depth interviews, the final report and presentation will be delivered to the client. Transcripts of research questions recordings are available on request and they can be provided at extra cost.

5. Timing

The Time Frame for this project is shown in the table below. The deadlines will be carefully considered making sure that the progression reports together with the final paper and presentation are provided on time. The first two copies of the report will be delivered after the first part of qualitative research is completed. It is recommended the field work to overlap the desk research in the early stage of the research with the purpose of overcoming time limitations. Though, the in-depth interviews are time consuming and they are expected to take place in week 3 to 6. Submission of the final report and presentation will follow in week 9 from signing-off the contract.

Figure 3 - Gantt chart – Timing



6. Budget

Identifying the main recycling issues in the industry, assessing L'Occitane ethical behaviour and evaluating its competition would require an extensive desk research. Therefore, 35 hours would be allocated for reviewing these aspects resulting in a total fee of £ 1750 (£ 50 per hour). Regarding the methodology, workshops have been found more suitable for this research than focus groups, but they are also more expensive. There will be 3 workshops whereas a fee of £ 3000 is charged for every one of them resulting in £ 9000. Following these research method, there will be 6 in-depth interviews every interview lasting for half an hour. £ 500 fee is charged for 1 hour, therefore 6 x ½ 1 H results in £ 1.5000. Monetary incentives will be provided for both qualitative methods - £ 30 per person attending the workshop and £ 50 for the interviewee. The Budget is detailed in the following table:

Figure 4 – Fees Illustration

Phase	Description	Budget
I. Desk research	35 hours x £50	£1,750.00
II. Observation	10 hours x £50	£500.00
III. Qualitative research		
A. Workshops	3 Workshops x £3000	£9,000.00
Incentive for Workshops	£30 per person x 22 per workshop	£1,980.00
B. In-depth Interviews	6 In-depth Interviews x £250 per 1/2 h	£1,500.00
Incentive for In-depth Interviews	£50 per person x 6 interviewee	£300.00

This costing estimate is operating on the fact that the official reports and informative source are free of charge. If this is not the case the costing can be amended. Also, the fees quoted are for the

services as set out in the Proposal. The Marketing Research Agency reserves the right to levy additional fees if the client requests changes to the project or its scale which results in higher costs. Therefore total cost of research project is planned to be £15.030 as shown in the table above.

7. Other Key Consideration

Limitations & Solutions

➤ **Overcoming Time Limitation – Use of Methodological Triangulation** (between-methods) so the findings could be questioned and complemented by comparing the data from the content analysis (observation), workshops and in-depth interviews. After the data is collected the researcher has the chance to assess the degree of similarity between the results coming from workshops and in-depth interview. If the findings from these two methods corroborate a mixed interpretation approach could be used in order to illustrate the findings. This action could save time by overlapping the analysis while it provides a fuller description and a more complete explanation of the stakeholders' attitudes about recycling.

Though, Triangulation also has a drawback requiring a multi-tasking proficient researcher who would charge a higher fee and it is very likely to experience subjectivity if the analysis is completed by a single person (investigator triangulation – use of different researchers could be considered).

➤ **Researcher Bias** - In order to identify the main stakeholders a Stakeholder Audit has been completed by assessing the most recent L'Occitane Annual Reports/Testimonials. Certainly, there are various stakeholders that have a direct or indirect input on the company, but this research will focus on Suppliers, Customers and Employees as the amount of time and money become restrictions for additional analysis. This approach may influence the results at it is a deliberate deprivation of other stakeholders' attitudes.

➤ **Methodology (Research Method) Limitation** - It must be stressed that, while the make-up of the workshops was designed to be broadly reflective of stakeholders' opinions about recycling, qualitative research can never be deemed to be representative of the population at large. Its main purpose is to provide insight into issues. Furthermore, awareness of the issues surrounding the use of recycling materials/ingredients might be low, especially among consumers and the findings of this work should therefore be considered in this context. Arguably, if participants would come to know more about the issues over time, they should be in a position to give a more informed response.

8. Credentials & Quality Control

Credentials & Quality Control

The project will be carried out by Apex Ltd, a market research agency specialized in work with beauty companies in Greater London.

It is the first research company in the United Kingdom promoting the market research in the cosmetic industry and it is successfully implementing ISO 20252, certified by British Standard Institute. Thus, we have achieved internationally equivalent quality and control for standardized steps in quantitative and qualitative research process.

The company's vision is to help our clients gaining insight into their customers' and stakeholders' needs anticipating their future requirements.

Our agency has published numerous articles and papers regarding marketing programs that seek to explore companies' ethical behaviour and stakeholders' satisfaction towards green practices.

These are often quoted by major trade publications canalizing the relationship between cosmetics and marketing industry.

One of our core missions is to offer accessible and open process for clients to accompany and observe at any time our research and findings.

For further credentials, we cordially invite you to visit our Apex website at www.apexmra.co.uk

Finally, all fieldwork meets the industry standards stipulated by the professional authorities, the MRS Code of Practice and CRM system tracking the research client satisfaction and monitoring the project quality. The in-depth interviews and workshops were conducted according with the MRS Code of Practice – assuring the participants of their anonymity and confidentiality of the results and findings.

Furthermore, as both qualitative research methods were recorded and written, the moderators asked for permission to use a recorder.

Chief Executive Officer
Diana A Florescu



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APPENDIX 1 - WORKSHOP

Description – Introductory Session

PLENARY SESSION 10.00 am to 2.00 p.m

Tea and Coffee served

- ☐ Thank participants for attending – mention that discussion should last from about 10am until 3.30pm.
- ☐ Introduce the Marketing Agency
- ☐ Introduce moderators
- ☐ Explain the research has been commissioned to explore issues about recycling and their attitudes towards this topic and L'Occitane recycling actions.

- ☐ Please stress that there are no right or wrong answers – we are just interested in finding out their views and opinions. Explain rules of workshop (e.g. give everyone the opportunity to speak; have a right to change your mind; no right or wrong answers, an informal discussion about their views and opinions. No technical expertise needed at all).

- ☐ Reassure participants about confidentiality – MRS code of conduct
- ☐ Recorders/photos – ask permission to record/take photographs (photos form)
- ☐ Explain break-out rooms/fire regulations/mobile phones/toilets
- ☐ Allocate break out groupings

APPENDIX 2 - IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS – INTRODUCTION & POSSIBLE DISCUSSION TOPICS

Introduction Key Components:	
• Thank you & Introduction (Name) • Purpose • Confidentiality • Duration • How interview will be conducted • Opportunity for questions • Signature of consent	I want to thank you for taking the time to meet with me today. My name is _____ and I would like to talk to you about your recycling experiences and attitudes towards L'Occitane position in regards with recycling. This interview is designed to assess your opinions about avoiding waste, protecting the environment, and L'Occitane “green actions” and how they are building corporate reputation. The interview should take less than an hour. Your comments will be taped and written to make sure I do not miss any of your comments. All responses will be kept confidential. This means that your interview responses will only be shared with research team members and we will ensure that any information we include in our report does not identify you as the respondent. Are there any questions about what I have just explained? Are you willing to participate in this interview? Interviewee _____ Witness Date _____ Legal guardian (if interviewee is under 18)
Possible Questions	<u>Recycling Issues</u> • Do you consider environmental issues in your daily life? What do you normally do? <u>Possible Answers:</u> Recycle Plastic and Glasses Buy Fair trade Label Try to reduce CO2 Look for Organic materials Try to reduce Pollution in other ways Try to shop ethically Shopping with human rights in mind • Do you believe the current ‘green fashion’ trend is really environmental friendly? If No, what made you distrust?

Possible Questions

L'Occitane & Recycling Issues

- **How often do you purchase L'Occitane Products?
What do you normally purchase?**

Guidance

Frequency - Weekly / Fortnightly / Monthly / Few times every year

Products – Cosmetics, Body care, Perfumes

- **What is important for you when you purchase these products?**

Possible Factors

Price / Quality / Brand (Reputation) / Environment friendly

- **Do you know any of L'Occitane green actions towards overcoming waste disposal/environmental pollution? If no, what prevented you from acknowledging these aspects? (Insufficient Information, Lack of Interest, Do not know where to look for it)**
- **Would you be willing to pay a great price for “green products”? If yes, when you purchase them which of the following elements could attract you to pay extra price for ‘green clothes’?**

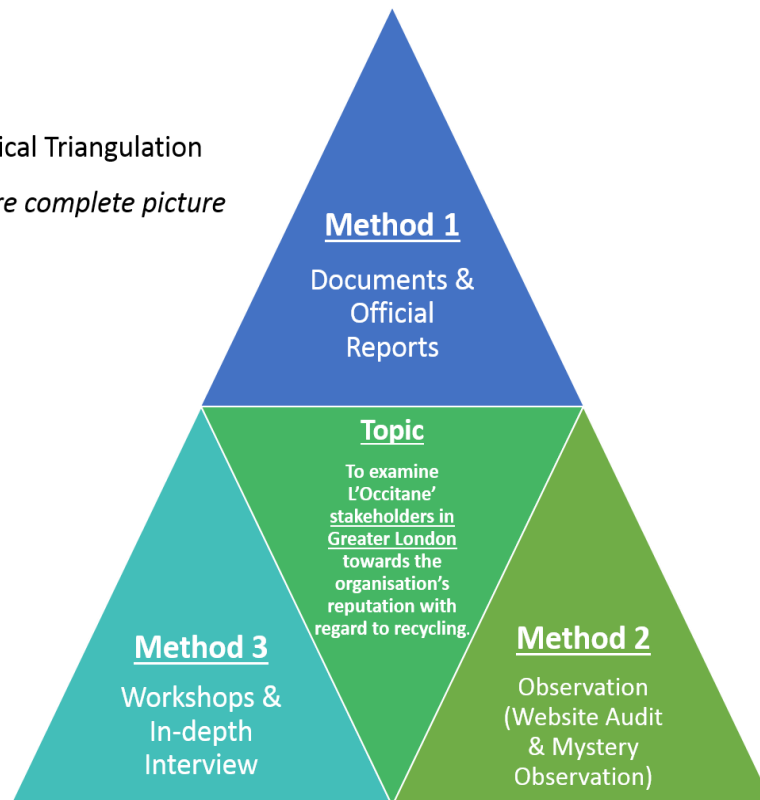
Marked as 100% recyclable, Use organic materials, Meet quality standard, Reduce pollution on dyeing, Labeling Standardizations for ‘green clothes’, Low carbon dioxide produced.

- **Do you consider a company’s sustainable action leads to a better reputation?**
- **Would you choose a retailer for its ethical reputation over another one which does not present a transparent “green behaviour”?**

*These Discussion Topics have been designed for an interview conducted among customers as “L'Occitane Stakeholders”. It is worth mentioning that the format and some questions are subject to change when suppliers or/and employees will be interviewed.

APPENDIX 3

Methodological Triangulation
Towards a more complete picture



Source: This graph has been created based on the research methods previously mentioned in the proposal.

APPENDIX 4



ON-SITE ANALYSIS

Content Review

- ☐ Goal-Focused (Recycling-Based)
- ☐ Accuracy and Reliability (up-to-date)
- ☐ Length

Page Design & Structure

- ☐ Complete and Relevant Title Tags
- ☐ Presence of additional sources in regards to recycling (links, CSR Reports, Testimonials)
- ☐ Degree of Engagement
- ☐ Social Media
- ☐ User Friendly – Accessible Data

Error Report

- ☐ Broken Links – Inaccessible Data
- ☐ Design issues (Broken Visuals)
- ☐ Challenging Page Layout & Loading Time

User Experience

- ☐ Degree of Engagement
- ☐ Social Media
- ☐ User Friendly – Accessible Data

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Competitive Site List

- ☐ Industry competitors (3-5 leaders that specialize in the beauty industry)
- ☐ Industry Publications & Associations (20-25 influential industry sites)

Content Analysis

* Based on the same variables used for L'Occitane

- ☐ Points of Parity & Difference
- ☐ User-generated Content
- ☐ Calls to action
- ☐ Quality of Links & Source generation

Source: The visual has been created based on the information provided on L'OCCITANE en Provence Website.

APPENDIX 5 – STORE LOCATOR (part of the Website Audit)

The screenshot displays the L'Occitane website's Boutique Locator interface. At the top, a navigation bar includes links for 'ABOUT US', 'MAGAZINE', 'BOUTIQUE LOCATOR', 'STORE EVENTS', and 'INTERNATIONAL'. A search bar is positioned on the right. Below this, a secondary navigation bar lists product categories: 'CHRISTMAS GIFTS', 'COLLECTIONS', 'FACE CARE', 'FRAGRANCE', 'BODY & BATH', 'HAIR CARE', 'MEN', 'SPECIAL OFFERS', 'NEW', and 'TRAVEL'. A promotional banner states 'FREE EXPRESS DELIVERY ON ALL ORDERS. ENDS 2PM FRIDAY 19TH DECEMBER 2014'.

The main content area is titled 'BOUTIQUE LOCATOR' and features the text: 'With more than 2000 boutiques in over 100 countries, L'OCCITANE brings the fragrances and skincare of Provence near you.' Below this, a 'Choose a country' dropdown menu is set to 'United Kingdom'. A 'London' input field is present, followed by an 'OK' button. To the left of the map, a list of locations is shown, including 'Melbury's' at '53 Turnham Green Terrace, Chiswick, London' and 'L'OCCITANE - Westfield' at 'Unit 1163a, Ground Floor, Westfield White City Shopping Centre'. Each entry includes a small L'Occitane logo and a 'View on map' link.

The map itself shows a detailed view of London, with numerous L'Occitane store locations marked by blue and yellow icons. A legend on the left side of the map identifies the icons: a blue icon for 'Boutique', a yellow icon for 'Stockist or Department Store', and a hot air balloon icon for 'Airport'. The map includes standard navigation controls like a compass and zoom in/out buttons.

Source: (L'OCCITANE en Provence, 2014)

Briefly critically evaluate, in no more than 250 words, **EACH** of the following statements:

I. Observation is secondary data collection

Observation can be defined as a **qualitative method** within the researcher relies on his abilities of observing behaviors and record what he sees. It could be done in four ways: a) direct versus indirect, b) overt versus covert, c) structured versus unstructured and d) in situ versus invented (Burns & Bush, 2014).

In the light of this short theory and evaluating the a) and c) categories in greater depth the observation becomes a much disputed topic in terms of being primary or secondary data collection. The key to this statement depends **on the observed object's nature**. Therefore, if a researcher wants to evaluate the waiting time customers need to spend for buying Costa Coffee, he can do so by observing directly people sitting at the queue. This approach has been used by some of the well-known brands such as Kellogg to understand breakfast routines or Cadbury for evaluating “chocoholics” buying behavior. The actual action is not preceded by other analysis or consulting secondary sources, instead it collects first-hand information. The **unstructured observation** supports this argument as it implies no predetermined restrictions or plans on what to observe, thus the researcher observes exactly what happens.

Though, I consider observation as secondary in cases such as observing **past actions, archives, physical traces or when a structured plan** exists beforehand by using secondary sources. For instance, L'Occitane stakeholders' attitudes towards recycling cannot be assessed until the main recycling issues in the industry are identified – by consulting environmental reports which makes observation a second-hand research.

II. Research errors are predominantly errors in question bias

In a research, error can be defined as the inconsistency between the results obtained through the study and the actual values possessed by the population involved in it. Total errors encompasses random sampling errors and non-sampling errors, the latter one comprising two main error categories - response error or non-response error. While the non-response error could be easily defined as a limitation coming from the lack of answers to the questions given, the

response errors attracts a great deal of attention as their source can be divided among researcher, the mediators/interviewers and the respondents themselves (Burns and Bush, 2014).

I consider the errors in question subjectivity being the most predominant as there are three parties who could generate the bias through answers inaccuracy, misunderstanding the questions or inappropriate questionnaire designs and questions order. Whether the selection process which proceeds the way questions are written and asked is imprecise or respondents wish to answer in a specific way, almost any survey confronts the limitation of question bias – people tend to treat a subject with a degree of subjectivity without having a deliberate reason. For example, a question such as “Do you drive irresponsibly?” is bias from both the researcher’s perspective – it depends of how he defines “irresponsibly” and the respondents’ view as most of them would say “No” to avoid critics.

The errors in question bias are directly influenced by the accuracy of the sampling size and the validity of the chosen research methods. If the respondents recruited or the research instrument are not suitable for the research, these errors will lead to short-sighted queries, answers and findings interpretation.

III. Ethical considerations are more important in qualitative research than in quantitative research

Ethical considerations are paramount in both research methods for assuring people of their confidentiality and anonymity and for not influencing the findings and their interpretation. Though, I believe ethical concerns do attract a greater deal of attention in qualitative research, especially when observation is used as a method (Drew, Hardman and Hosp, 2008).

Quantitative research involves counting the behaviours, errors or other variables recorded in terms of quantity. It comprises both experimental and non-experimental research, the former one being more sensitive as participants’ self-disclosure is often required. However, the investigator can diminish ethical issues through transparency, obtaining consent and explaining their rights. Same approach is used for non-experimental research which is considered to be even less harmful than the previous one. Thus, the researcher has a certain degree of control over ethical issues at this stage, but he might not be able to do so in qualitative research.

In a participant/non-participant observation, informed consent is not sufficient as the participants who give their approval may not be the only people observed. Another problem could be even the research disclosure as this may alter people's natural behaviour as soon as they know they are observed. Furthermore, some participants can become enough comfortable with this procedure to forget they are being monitored, thus the consent is no longer effective.

Finally, the sensitive data collected through qualitative research is an invasion of privacy which cannot be always overcome by assuring anonymity. It fails when privacy questions regarding sacred information are addressed as they may never be appropriate.

IV. Projective techniques are never used in quantitative research.

Projecting techniques involve finding out about people through various associations that allow respondents to divulge and express things about themselves that they might not reveal under direct questioning. Five main projective techniques are used by marketers – the word association test, the sentence completion test, picture test, cartoon or balloon test and role-playing activity. Such techniques are indeed more often used in qualitative research due to the sensitive data collected, but they can also be adopted in quantitative studies as “well-worded open-ended questions” (Bradley, 2010)

According with the techniques previously mentioned, I believe the sentence completion test could be adopted in form of open-ended questions and they could be used in quantitative research. In these cases, the aim is to represent and condense data into numbers and by doing so the researcher has to run a deductive process assigning a numerical value to each likely response. This method may be time consuming as the investigator has to consider the possible answers to the open-ended questions and afterwards, he has to review respondents' answers and allocate the numerical value that best matches his expected response. Except the limitations, this approach proves the use of projecting techniques in quantitative research.